

Small business tax filing checklist guide by entity type with step-by-step instructions — Action Checklist

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IDENTIFY YOUR ENTITY TYPE

- ☐ **Check Your State Filing:** Visit your state Secretary of State website and search for your business name to confirm whether you filed articles of incorporation, organization, or a certificate of formation, which determines if you have a formal entity.
- ☐ **Use the Decision Tree:** Follow the five-question decision tree in Chapter 1 to systematically determine whether you are a sole proprietor, LLC, S-corp, or corporation by answering each question honestly and moving to the next step.
- ☐ **Count Your Owners:** Determine whether you operate as a single-member or multi-member business because this single fact changes whether you file Schedule C, Form 1065, or Form 1120-S and determines your entire tax filing path.
- ☐ **Document Your Entity in Writing:** Write your entity type in one complete sentence such as 'I am a single-member LLC taxed as a sole proprietor' and keep this sentence on every form you file as your consistent reference point.

FILE THE RIGHT FORMS

- ☐ **File Schedule C With Your 1040:** Attach Schedule C to your personal Form 1040 if you are a sole proprietor or single-member LLC because your business income and expenses ride along with your personal taxes rather than getting a separate return.
- ☐ **File Form 1065 for Multi-Member LLCs:** File Form 1065 and issue a Schedule K-1 to each partner if you have a multi-member LLC that has not elected S-corp status because partnerships do not pay tax at the entity level.
- ☐ **File Form 1120-S for S-Corp Elections:** File Form 1120-S and issue Schedule K-1s to each shareholder if you elected S-corp status for your LLC or corporation because S-corps also pass income through to individual tax returns.
- ☐ **Map Numbers to Specific IRS Boxes:** Ensure every business income and expense figure goes into the correct specific box on the correct specific form because the IRS requires numbers in exact boxes, not a general spreadsheet submission.

ORGANIZE YOUR FILING PROCESS

- ☐ **Create a Reference Cheat Sheet:** Write down or print the entity type cheat sheet showing which form corresponds to your business type and tape it to your desk so you never file the wrong form again.
 - ☐ **Issue K-1s Before Filing Deadlines:** Prepare and issue Schedule K-1s to all partners or shareholders before your personal filing deadline because each recipient needs their K-1 to complete their own individual tax return.
 - ☐ **Gather Income and Expense Records:** Collect all revenue documents, receipts, and expense records organized by category before opening any tax form because completing the correct form requires having your numbers ready in advance.
 - ☐ **Keep Completed Returns Accessible:** Save digital and physical copies of every filed tax return and K-1 in a dedicated business tax folder because you will need these documents for future filings, audits, and business planning.
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